

You have to tell parents that it is your children we are thinking of; it is your children's future. In the globalised world we have to change to be bold, we have to face the challenges of tomorrow and the only way to do it is to allow the child to discover his own genius and free the child from being imprisoned within the walls of the classroom and being told that all your learning depends on whether you are able to mug up this book or not. And let the children dream for themselves. That's the way forward.

At the moment, for every 100 children that go to school only 13 children reach college. It is a national disaster, because in sub-Saharan Africa, the percentage is 6, and the global average is 23. My aim is that by 2020, instead of 13 we should have 30 out of hundred reaching college. The biggest challenge is how to provide for those 30 per cent, because that in real numbers would mean an extra 40 million going to college. You need to open up the system; in other words you need as much private investment in education as is possible.

You can't have educational institutions that do not have quality. I have put up the National Accreditation Council. Every institution in India, every so-called deemed university in India will have to be accredited. This job will be performed by a separate independent authority of experts. But in the process there will be a lot of disputes. You cannot take recourse to ordinary courts because that takes years, so I have set up the National Educational Tribunal Act for setting up tribunals at the state and Central levels to deal with the disputes that will come up. That's the second piece of legislation. We want to move away from an inspector raj in higher education. I am moving towards a self-disclosure mechanism for schools and educational institutions.

Then we have the Foreign Education Providers Bill. This will allow all quality foreign education providers to come into the country and offer twinning arrangements, exchange arrangements, set up degrees, etc. In a little

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SESSION CHAIRPERSON RAJ CHENGAPPA (LEFT) DISCUSSES THE FUTURE OF EDUCATION WITH HRD MINISTER KAPIL SIBAL

while we will have the National Council for Higher Education in place. This whole system will be decentralised. That's the vision for higher education.

But there is another set of people who are not a part of this. So we need to enhance the space of skill development. We must allow industry in the private sector to set up institutions for skill development. And we must make sure the skills imparted are quality skills. I am trying to change Class X and XII curricula as well and bringing some vocational training into them.

We need to look at things differently, we need to change, and we need to think of infinite possibilities. And the 21st century needs that. We will have a middle class of eight hundred million in a decade or two and we will have all our children go to school, 30 per cent going to college and we will have intangible wealth which will match anyone in the world.

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DISCUSSION

Q. You spoke of public-private partnerships for the higher education sector. Are there any thoughts of opening up the school sector in almost the same dimensions to the private sector?

A. I don't think the school sector will open up in the same dimension because if you look at school education in this country 93 per cent is controlled by the government today and 7 per cent is in the private sector. You can't change that paradigm, what you can bring the private sector into management. It

should be allowed to work with the public sector, but lots of public sector schools may not want to work.

Q. What are the hurdles that the government faces when employing new teachers or retraining them. Is it lack of will, lack of talent, or is it just sheer laziness on the part of the state governments?

A. No, it's a market phenomenon, why would I want to become a teacher? Why? Because they think that they can earn much more becoming a doctor or an engineer.

They know they won't be allowed to teach anywhere else, like in a university. So people don't go into the teaching profession. It has nothing to do with the laziness of the state government.

Q. Would you be looking into the pressure put on the students when they have to meet ambitious cut-offs set by colleges at the time of admission?

A. Yes, we are looking into it very seriously. We want to make a core curriculum and are trying to hold one examination for all of India

in the science stream. Once that is done there won't be 10 different examinations. There would be two important ones in Class XI before a child moves into higher education. One is subject matter knowledge. The other tests fundamental knowledge of the subject, understanding of it, raw intelligence and sense of awareness of other issues connected with the subject. Like the SAT. Finally an all-India merit list will be brought out so one can choose colleges and vice versa. And there won't be a capitation fee either.